

Set limits without losing connection

The A-C-T approach for calm, clear boundaries

Connect with the feeling. Hold the boundary. Guide the next choice.

A limit can be both warm and firm.

Children need adults to accept their feelings while keeping behavior safe. ACT gives you a simple sequence to use when emotions are high. You are not approving the behavior; you are showing your child that every feeling is welcome and some actions still have limits.



Acknowledge

the feeling, wish, or want

TRY SAYING

"You are really angry. You wanted one more turn."



Communicate

the limit clearly and briefly

TRY SAYING

"The blocks are not for throwing at people."



Target

an acceptable alternative

TRY SAYING

"You may knock down your tower or throw these soft balls into the basket."

PUT IT TOGETHER

"You are angry with your brother. I am not for hitting."
"You can hit this pillow or stomp your feet beside me."

Keep it usable in the hard moment

- 1 Regulate first**
Lower your voice, slow your pace, and use fewer words.
- 2 Name what you see**
Reflect the likely feeling or wish; you do not need to be perfectly right.
- 3 State the limit once**
Describe what is not allowed without a lecture, threat, or shame.
- 4 Offer safe choices**
Give one or two realistic alternatives you are ready to support.

Practice your own ACT response

A My child feels or wants...

C The limit is...

T A safe alternative is...



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Connection first. Clear limits. Safe choices.

Source: Landreth, G. L. (2023). Play Therapy (4th ed.). Routledge.